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Blog

Vermont Utility's Radical New Community Solar Plan

CHAZ WILKE ([HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/AUTHOR/CHAZW/](https://solarmehome.com/author/chazw/)) / SEPTEMBER 28, 2015 ([HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/VERMONT-UTILITYS-RADICAL-NEW-COMMUNITY-SOLAR-PLAN/](https://solarmehome.com/vermont-utilitys-radical-new-community-solar-plan/))



It's hard to read any news site these days without hearing about how we are now in the sharing economy. Those with are now able to provide to those without. Why not apply that philosophy to community solar?

Yeloha, a Vermont-based startup utility company is applying the sharing economy basics to energy production and consumption. With Sun Hosts and Sun Partners, you can now reap the benefits of solar panels without the need to have them on your own roof. This is one of those ideas that seems obvious after you hear it, yet only now we are seeing a utility company adopt it.

Fast Company called Yeloha the "Airbnb for Energy (<http://bit.ly/1P1PC50>)," and the similarities are clear as a sunny day. At peak energy production during the middle of the day, there's a good chance those with solar panels aren't using all the energy they are producing. So, instead of selling the energy back to the grid using net metering or a feed in tariff program, Yeloha just diverts that solar-produced energy to another customer.

Expanding the customer base

GTM Research released (<http://bit.ly/1KOv9eJ>) sobering news on the number of households that are a good fit for rooftop solar panels. Winnowing the numbers are factors like location, roof type, or economic reasons among others. Of the 116.8 million U.S. households, only 15.8 million are considered an "addressable market" for rooftop solar PV panels. This leaves 101 million households in a tough spot for owning or leasing panels of

their own. This is the market that Yeloha aims to target head on.

Using a peer-to-peer network, Yeloha will allow users to subscribe to solar energy that may be generated by anyone in the network that has solar panels. Your energy could be coming from as close as your neighbor's roof. And that is a pretty simple sales pitch, especially to the underserved market of households that might not be a perfect fit for panels of their own.

Yuliya Chernova of the *Wall Street Journal* explains (<http://on.wsj.com/1PJBXNY>) the details on how the solar sharing program works:

"A homeowner whose roof is well-suited for solar energy receives a solar system free. As the solar system starts generating energy, the host sees a reduction on his or her utility bill. The host receives credit for about 25% to 30% of the energy produced and pays nothing. Yeloha doesn't care about a homeowner's credit score, since the homeowner doesn't have to pay anything to Yeloha."

This means apartment dwellers and homeowners that have incompatible roofs can buy in to solar generated power and still save money. Another huge benefit outlined by Yeloha is that subscribers can move within the same utility zone and still participate in the program.



Takeaway

It is reassuring to see those who have decided on independent solar power generation to be willing to join a community solar network that helps those without panels themselves. Companies like Yeloha prove that the solar energy revolution can be democratized. Since many utility companies across this nation are either resistant or sluggish to adopt solar as a legitimate energy source, it is heartening to see new companies rising to the challenge.

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